

Full Project Report - ONS Wellbeing Analysis (2011-2022)

A Data-Driven Exploration of UK Wellbeing Trends

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1. Executive Summary

This report analyses ONS wellbeing data from 2011-2022, exploring national trends, regional differences, and the influence of major world events on the wellbeing of UK residents. The findings show that positive wellbeing measures (Life Satisfaction, Happiness, Worthwhile) declined during the pandemic years, while Anxiety increased. Some regions, such as Dartford, bucked national patterns, demonstrating resilience during periods of national stress. The analysis also highlights geographical divides, with northern regions consistently outperforming major cities, and shows how wellbeing trends closely mirror global and economic events. Overall, the UK's average wellbeing score across the dataset is 6.47/10.

2. Findings

1. National wellbeing shifted sharply during the pandemic (2020-2022)

Life Satisfaction, Happiness, and Worthwhile all declined during the pandemic, reflecting the emotional strain of lockdowns, social isolation, and disrupted routines. Anxiety increased, rising above the long-term national average due to uncertainty around health, employment, finances, and the future. Together, these trends show that positive wellbeing fell while anxiety rose.

2. Dartford bucked the national trend in 2021

While the national average anxiety score increased in 2021 (3.08 vs 2.98 long-term), Dartford recorded its lowest anxiety score in the entire dataset. Remote working, reduced commuting stress, lower transport costs, and more time at home likely contributed to this. Although anxiety rose again in 2022, Dartford remains consistently below the national average.

3. Anxiety highest in London boroughs, except in 2016

London boroughs dominate the highest anxiety scores in most years due to high living costs, long commutes, dense population, and lower community cohesion. In 2016, Oxford and Cambridge enter the top three, likely linked to Brexit-related uncertainty affecting student-heavy populations.

4. Northern regions score highest for Happiness, Life Satisfaction, and Worthwhile

Scotland and Northern Ireland consistently perform strongly across positive wellbeing measures. Rural lifestyles, lower housing costs, shorter commutes, and stronger community ties contribute to higher wellbeing. Major cities, particularly London, tend to score lower due to financial pressures and fast-paced living.

5. The UK's overall wellbeing score is 6.47/10

This serves as a benchmark for comparing regional performance. Areas above 6.47 show relatively strong wellbeing; those below may face socioeconomic challenges.

6. Wellbeing trends mirror major world events

Wellbeing improves in the early 2010s following recovery from the late-2000s recession. It dips around 2016 during Brexit uncertainty and declines sharply in 2020 with the onset of COVID-19. Although the dataset ends in 2022, global instability - including the war in Ukraine, tensions in Iran, and international trade pressures - suggests wellbeing may continue to be affected beyond the dataset.

3. Reflection

This project strengthened my skills in data cleaning, modelling, and visualisation using Power BI. Preparing the dataset required removing metadata rows, unpivoting year columns, and creating calculated fields to support dynamic visuals. One of the biggest challenges was ensuring the national average remained fixed on line charts while regional values changed - solved using DAX functions such as ALLEXCEPT. Designing intuitive visuals, including heat maps, KPI cards, and trend lines, helped present the data clearly and accessibly.

The analysis revealed meaningful insights into how wellbeing responds to economic, social, and global pressures. If more time were available, I would explore forecasting models, deeper regional comparisons, and interactive drill-through pages to enhance the dashboard further.